

CATENA

Research Foundation, Competitive Analysis, and Design Review

Forest, Focus Friend and Finch analyzed through the MDA framework

Abstract

This document examines the design rationale for Catena, a gamified focus application that combines the Pomodoro method with cozy game aesthetics. Section one surveys the research literature on attention, habit formation, and motivation, establishing three problem behaviors that emerge from the modern attention economy: reactive impulsiveness, task paralysis, and continuous partial attention. Section two validates these behaviors through an intro questionnaire of **61 students**, finding that focus difficulty is near-universal in the target population and that engagement decay, not feature dissatisfaction, drives churn in the category. Section three analyzes three competing focus tools, Forest, Focus Friend, and Finch, through the **MDA** framework of mechanics, dynamics, and aesthetics. The document closes by identifying a structural gap in the existing landscape: no current tool simultaneously delivers cozy aesthetic comfort, forgiving dynamics, and real-time co-presence with other users. This is the gap Catena is designed to occupy. Lastly we analyze Catena based on the opening questionnaire and MDA framework to inform future development.

Executive Overview

Catena is a gamified focus application that blends the Pomodoro method with the charm of cozy games, a genre that has surged in recent years, with 53% of players reporting they turn to cozy games to switch off from everyday stress and anxiety (Sago, 2025). The name Catena means a connected series or chain of related items, ideas, or organisms, which is a nod to how the app chains together focus sessions to build long-term focus habits. The naming ties directly into the gamified loop at the core of the product.

This document examines the behaviors Catena is designed to address, including the attention economy, information overload, and the ways gamification can support productivity for neurodivergent users in particular. It also reviews the research showing how social spaces and co-presence contribute to mental health. From there, it surveys the existing competitive landscape across three apps. Forest was selected as the most popular option in the category. Focus Friend by Hank Green was selected for its similar gentle, ethos-driven approach to focus. Finch was included as a general ADHD-oriented productivity and self-care app. Each is compared against Catena to identify which features overlap, where Catena can improve on the existing pattern, and where it diverges entirely.

In short, Catena differentiates itself through an active game loop set in an immersive world of cats, a layer of world-building absent from all three competitors. By pairing a reward mechanism through the cat cafe with a productivity engine in the form of a pomodoro timer and stopwatch, Catena aims to build sustained motivation to focus in a way the current category does not.

Research Foundation

The Behavioral Environment Problem

Human attention has not changed in any meaningful biological sense over the past two decades, but the environments in which it operates have been radically restructured. Digital platforms now compete actively for attention as a tradable resource, producing what Vettehen and Schaap (2023) describe as a spiral of attention scarcity: as platforms intensify their attention-grabbing tactics, attention becomes scarcer, which provokes still more aggressive tactics.

The scale of this restructuring is significant. Global media consumption reached 8 hours per day by 2019, and in the United States nearly 11 hours daily, with mobile devices filling every available gap (Vettehen & Schaap, 2023). Many users now spend more time staring at screens than they spend sleeping. The techniques deployed against attention have evolved alongside the consumption: Vettehen and Schaap identify three categories of escalating sophistication, from broadly appealing content, to group-targeted content, to algorithmically personalized feeds that refine themselves with every interaction. The more relevant the content feels, the more the user engages, the more data the system collects, the more precisely it can target.

The cognitive cost is documented. Inattentive media use, including channel zapping, endless scrolling, and media multitasking, produces what the authors call an illusion of knowledge: users believe they have learned from the consumption while performing poorly on actual knowledge tests (Vettehen & Schaap, 2023). Deep learning requires sustained attention, and the attention-grabbing environment is structurally hostile to it. The downstream effects extend beyond cognition: excessive screen time is consistently associated with sleep problems, depression, ADHD-related behaviors, and decreased cognitive control.

This is the environment in which a focus-oriented product must operate. It cannot be designed as a neutral tool dropped into a neutral context. It is intervening in an actively hostile attentional landscape.

Three Problem Behaviors

The hostile environment produces a distinct cluster of behaviors. Three of them matter most for the design of any focus intervention.

Reactive Impulsiveness

The first problem behavior is reactive impulsiveness: responding to digital cues before conscious intent can intervene. Wood and R nger (2016) demonstrate that habits form through context-response associations stamped in by repeated dopamine reinforcement, and that approximately 43% of daily actions are performed habitually rather than through deliberate choice. Once a cue is established, it fires automatically whenever encountered. The phone in the pocket, the open browser tab, the notification preview on the lock screen, each is a cue engineered to trigger habitual response. The user does not choose to check the phone in the same way they choose what to have for dinner. The choice has already

been made by an established habit pattern, and the conscious experience of checking is largely a post-hoc rationalization.

This explains why willpower-based interventions fail. Clear (2018), the author of the *Atomic Habits* summarizes the design implication: people do not rise to the level of their goals; they fall to the level of their systems. Sustainable behavior change requires restructuring cues themselves rather than reinforcing the user's ability to resist them. Vettehen and Schaap (2023) reinforce this from the opposite direction, noting that user-side resistance strategies, such as ad blockers and digital detoxes, show promise but are cognitively demanding. Resistance is structurally an uphill battle.

Task Paralysis

The second problem behavior, particularly acute among neurodivergent users, is task paralysis: the inability to initiate tasks despite a clear intention to do so. Eagle et al. (2024), in the first peer-reviewed study of body doubling, document that neurodivergent participants describe ordinary tasks, such as laundry, studying, and replying to messages, as requiring a kind of cognitive activation energy that is not always available. The task is not difficult in itself. Starting it is. Their participants describe needing external scaffolding to overcome this initiation barrier, often in the form of another person's presence, even when no interaction occurs.

Task paralysis is not a motivational failure. It is an executive function pattern that interacts badly with environments demanding constant self-initiation. This is the population for whom traditional focus tools fail most visibly: highly motivated to focus, structurally unable to begin.

Continuous Partial Attention

The third problem behavior is continuous partial attention, the state of monitoring multiple information streams at low depth rather than engaging any single one fully. Martin et al. (2025), in a systematic review of digital distraction in educational contexts, found that technology-related factors account for 51.95% of distraction causes and produce a measurable decline in flow state achievement. Arnold et al. (2023) document that 22.5% of users now cite information overload as a major daily stressor, with measurable links to performance loss and decision-making errors.

For neurodivergent users, this layer compounds the previous two. A brain already prone to task paralysis and reactive cue-response is now operating in an environment that actively trains it to attend partially to everything and fully to nothing.

Why Conventional Interventions Fail

These three behaviors share a common feature: they are responses to environmental design, not faults of the individual. This is the central insight of habit-formation research (Wood & Rünger, 2016) and the central premise of self-determination theory (Ryan & Deci, 2000). Behavior is shaped by the conditions in which it occurs. Ryan and Deci argue that human motivation depends on the satisfaction of three innate psychological needs. **Autonomy** is the experience of acting volitionally, with a sense that one's behavior

is self-directed rather than externally imposed. **Competence** is the experience of effective mastery, the sense of being able to produce desired outcomes through one's own actions. **Relatedness** is the experience of meaningful connection to others, the sense of belonging to a group or being cared for. When environments frustrate these three needs, users experience alienation and passivity regardless of how much they want to focus. When environments support them, users move toward intrinsic motivation and sustained engagement without requiring constant willpower expenditure.

The Target Behaviors a Successful Intervention Should Produce

The research literature converges on three target behaviors that successful focus interventions cultivate.

The first is showing up consistently in small doses. Habit research suggests that the most reliable predictor of long-term behavior change is not session length or intensity but session frequency and consistency (Wood & Rünger, 2016). Clear (2018) translates this into the design principle of making the desired behavior easy enough that beginning is trivial, allowing identity-level change to accumulate from many small reinforcements rather than from a few effortful ones.

The second is engaging through play rather than discipline. Li et al. (2023), in a meta-analysis of 41 studies and over 5,000 participants, confirmed a large effect size ($g = 0.822$) for gamified interventions on learning outcomes, with the largest effects appearing in long-term implementations sustained beyond one semester. Their analysis uses the MDA framework, namely Mechanics, Dynamics, and Aesthetics, to characterize what makes gamification effective. Mechanics are the quantifiable components such as points and rewards. Dynamics describe how those mechanics interact over time through tasks and feedback loops. Aesthetics are the emotional responses produced: challenge, companionship, satisfaction, calm. Importantly, Li and colleagues found that motivation showed the largest effect size in their meta-analysis, followed by academic performance, with engagement showing the weakest effect, suggesting that gamification's primary mechanism is the cultivation of intrinsic motivation rather than surface engagement.

This is reinforced by the ADHD-specific literature. Alabdulkareem and Jamjoom (2020), in their review of gamified interventions for ADHD users, found that participants performed equivalently to neurotypical peers when tasks were framed as games, despite underperforming in standard settings. Game-like framing reduces the executive-function load of self-regulation by externalizing the reward structure: rather than relying on internal motivation, the user is responding to feedback in the environment. The wellbeing literature reinforces this. Hazel et al. (2022), in a cross-sectional study of over two thousand adult gamers, found that 88.4% reported emotional benefits from play, with the strongest effects appearing when games satisfied autonomy, competence, and relatedness simultaneously. Cozy games specifically have been documented to support emotional regulation, with 53% of players citing exactly this purpose (Sago, 2025; DiBenedetto, 2025).

The third is focusing in the presence of others. Eagle et al. (2024) document that body doubling functions as ambient accountability for neurodivergent users: the mere presence of another person, including through technologically mediated forms like study-with-me streams, helps users overcome task

paralysis and sustain engagement. This satisfies the relatedness need that Ryan and Deci (2000) identify as foundational, and does so without requiring direct interaction or scheduled co-working sessions. The user is alone-together, which appears to be the structural sweet spot for many neurodivergent focus patterns.

What the Research Asks of a Focus Product

Taken together, the literature points to a specific shape for any successful intervention in this space. It must restructure cues rather than rely on willpower. It must lower the activation energy required to begin a session, not raise it. It must reward effort through play and visible progress rather than punish failure through guilt or loss. And it must offer co-presence as a structural feature rather than an optional add-on, particularly for the neurodivergent users who are simultaneously the most underserved by current focus tools and the most receptive to ones designed with their cognitive patterns in mind.

With this foundation in place, the following analysis examines three existing focus tools, Forest, Focus Friend, and Finch, through the lens of the MDA framework. Each app is evaluated on its mechanics, dynamics, and aesthetics, with screenshots tagged to the specific framework component each demonstrates. Each analysis closes by assessing how well the app delivers on the three target behaviors identified above.

Validating the Research Through Target Users

To test whether the behaviors identified in the research foundation hold for Catena's intended users, an intro questionnaire was distributed to 61 students in April 2026. The sample skews late-college, with broad disciplinary representation across computer science, biology, neuroscience, design, music composition, business, education, and others, suggesting the focus pain point cuts across academic specialties rather than concentrating in any single major. The sample is network-sourced, with Wellesley College and MIT together accounting for 30% of responses, so quantitative claims should be read as directional rather than representative of the broader focus-app market.

Age bucket	Respondents	Share
High school (15–17)	9	15%
Early college (18–19)	11	18%
Late college (20–22)	37	61%
Post-college (23+)	4	7%

Confirming the Three Problem Behaviors

The questionnaire confirms all three problem behaviors identified in the research foundation. Sixty-six percent of respondents reported struggling to focus "often" or "always" while studying, and zero

respondents reported "never" struggling. Even self-described well-functioning students showed a 45% rate of frequent focus difficulty, suggesting the bullseye user is not a catastrophically struggling student but a functional-but-inconsistent one. Sixty-two percent of respondents placed themselves in the middle of the four-option self-description scale: basically functional, but inconsistent. This has direct implications for product framing. A brand voice that assumes the user is failing will alienate the bullseye user, and so will a voice that assumes the user is already optimized.

Respondents were asked to pick one of four self-descriptions.

Self-description	Count	Share
I'm pretty good, but with occasional off days	22	36%
I can be a little bit inconsistent	25	41%
I have a hard time studying most of the time	13	21%
Near perfect... I'm an academic weapon	1	2%

Question: "Do you find it hard to focus when you're trying to study?"

Response	Count	Share
Always	15	25%
Often	25	41%
Sometimes	21	34%
Never	0	0%

Habit self-description vs. focus difficulty

Self-described habits	% struggling often or always	n
I have a hard time studying most of the time	100%	13
I can be a little bit inconsistent	68%	25
I'm pretty good, but with off days	45%	22
Near perfect	0%	1

The cause of focus difficulty mapped cleanly onto two categories. Among respondents who struggle often or always, social media was named as a primary culprit by 43 respondents, and stress was named by 42, appearing in roughly equal weight. This finding matters because the two demand fundamentally different design responses. Social media is a friction problem, addressed by removing or restructuring cues. Stress is a nervous-system problem, addressed by calming environment design and pacing that does not pile pressure on top of pressure. Most existing focus apps in the category, including Forest and Flora, treat

focus exclusively as a social-media-friction problem; the data suggests this leaves roughly half of the user pain unaddressed.

Primary culprits

Culprit	Mentions
Social media	43
Stress	42
Games	11
ADHD (named)	~3

Among the 15 most acutely affected respondents, those who struggle "always," stress appeared in over two-thirds of culprit lists, often paired with social media. ADHD was named directly by three of these 15. The more severely a respondent struggled, the more stress dominated as the actual blocker. This argues for a calming, wellness-leaning brand voice for the heaviest-need users, rather than a discipline or lock-in framing.

Task paralysis appeared as a distinct behavioral pattern, separate from focus-during-session difficulty. Ten respondents named procrastination or starting as the primary thing they wanted to improve. One respondent captured the pattern cleanly: "I struggle the most with simply starting my tasks, once I get going it's not bad but I can't even get myself to start sometimes." This confirms the body-doubling literature's finding that initiation and sustained focus are distinct problems requiring distinct interventions (Eagle et al., 2024).

Three Findings Beyond the Literature

Beyond confirming the research foundation, the questionnaire surfaced three findings that go beyond what the published literature predicts and that should shape Catena's design directly.

The first is that engagement decay, not feature dissatisfaction, is the dominant cause of churn in this category. When asked why they stopped using previous focus apps, 26 respondents said they forgot about it and 19 said they lost interest, totaling 45 mentions of engagement-failure reasons. By contrast, only 12 mentions cited functional dissatisfaction across all three categories of "not helpful," "too complicated," and "features were paywalled" combined. Users do not abandon focus apps because the apps lack features. They abandon them because they stop opening them. This finding has direct implications for the MDA framework that structures the competitor analysis: the dynamics layer, where retention mechanics live, is where this category is won or lost.

Reason for stopping	Mentions
Forgot about it	26
Lost interest	19

Not helpful	9
Too complicated	2
Features were paywalled	1
Still using (haven't stopped)	12

The second is that respondents framed their study struggles in emotional and identity terms rather than productivity terms. When asked what they wanted to improve, recurring language across open-ended responses included pride, excitement, motivation, engagement, not feeling overwhelmed, not giving up, and "find a method that works for me." What people are asking for is harder than features: discipline, motivation, identity, and emotional support. One Babson respondent summarized the entire pattern in seven words: "Just help me feel more pride and excitement in it." This aligns with the self-determination theory finding that intrinsic motivation depends on autonomy, competence, and relatedness rather than on external pressure (Ryan & Deci, 2000), and it suggests that copy and tone choices are not surface-level decisions in this category. A focus session that ends with a sense of pride is qualitatively different from one that ends with a number, even if the underlying mechanic is identical.

Theme	Mentions
Focus / concentration	15
Consistency	13
Longer sessions	10
Procrastination / starting	10
Time management / efficiency	9
Burnout / balance	4
Retention / actually learning	3

The third is that 39% of respondents had never used a productivity or focus app at all. This greenfield audience is not comparing Catena to Forest or to Focus Friend. For these users, onboarding is not a competitive comparison; it is the introduction of an entirely new category. This reframes the strategic question. The dominant frame in app analysis is how a new product wins against established competitors. The questionnaire suggests the larger and more accessible market is how a new product establishes the category for users who have never tried it before. For a product positioned in cozy gaming and gentle accountability, the greenfield audience is likely more receptive than the audience that has already been disappointed by Forest's monetization decisions or by Focus Friend's content depth.

App	Mentions	Notes
Forest	12	Category leader

Notion	12	Different category (organization, not focus)
Focus Friend	9	
Flora	5	
Todoist	3	
Pomodoro timers (generic)	3	
Finch	2	
CatOnChair	2	
YPT	2	Korean co-studying app
On Together	1	Social co-study
Endel, Study Bunny, others	1 each	

The Entry Problem and the Continuation Problem

One additional finding deserves mention because it shapes the design constraints Catena must address. The questionnaire reveals that focus apps must solve two distinct problems, not one. The first is the entry problem: getting users to open the app at all, particularly users who experience task paralysis. The second is the continuation problem: keeping users in the session once they have started. The research literature (Eagle et al., 2024) implicitly addresses both, but most existing focus apps assume the user has already begun. A timer-based intervention is useless to a user who cannot bring themselves to start the timer. This suggests Catena's design must include a low-friction entry mechanic distinct from its in-session mechanics, a constraint the competitor analysis evaluates each existing tool against.

Methodological Limits

Several limitations bound the conclusions above. The sample is self-selected and network-sourced, with respondents knowing the questionnaire was for a focus-app project, which likely inflates self-reports of focus difficulty. The 0% "never struggle" floor reflects the sample, not the general population. Cross-tabs by age sub-segment are based on small numbers in some buckets, particularly the post-college cohort (n=4) and the high school cohort (n=9), and should be read as directional. Behavioral data from TestFlight users will provide stronger evidence and should be reconciled against these self-reports as the product develops. All quantitative claims rest on $n \leq 61$.

Existing Focus Tools Through the MDA Framework

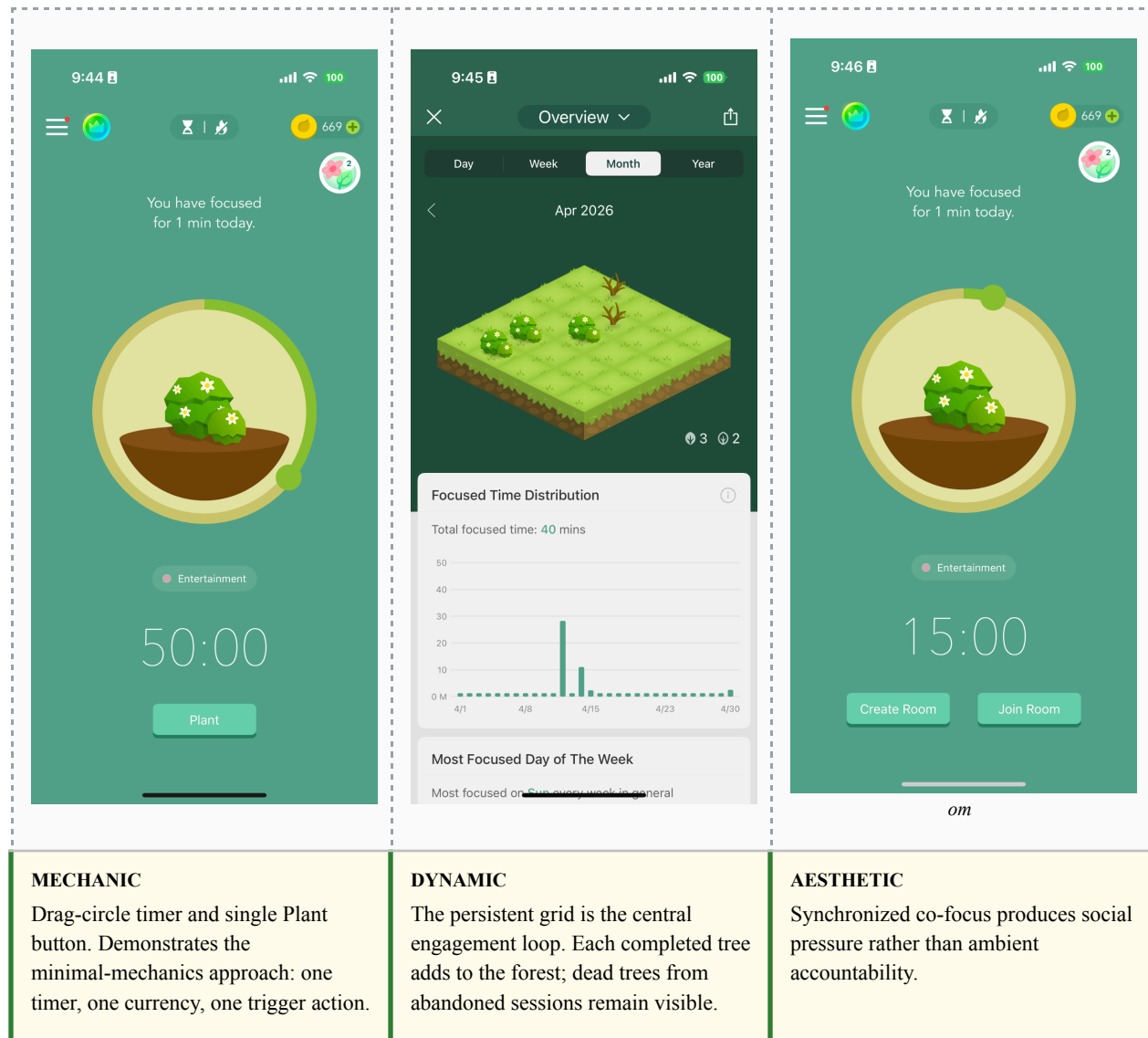


1. Forest

Released in 2014 by Seekrtech, Forest is the longest-running app in the focus-gamification category, with approximately 95 million downloads and a 4.39 rating on Google Play. It uses a single-purchase pricing model on iOS at \$3.99, which has earned it durable user loyalty in a category increasingly dominated by subscriptions. However, they have started a premium tier that is subscription based on top of the paid app that unlocks more features. The core promise is simple: plant a virtual tree at the start of a focus session, and if the user leaves the app before the timer ends, the tree dies.

Forest MDA Breakdown	
Mechanics	• Drag-circle timer with user-set duration • Coin currency, accrued proportional to session length • Tree species shop, deterministic purchase, no randomization • User-defined tags (work, study, music, meditation) for time accounting • Real-world tree donation threshold at 2,500 coins, capped at five trees per user • Plant Together synchronized co-focus rooms (premium-only)
Dynamics	• Persistent forest grid functions as a trophy case for completed sessions • Dead trees from abandoned sessions remain visible until removed for 60 coins • Sunk-cost engagement loop: visible accumulation drives continued use • Plant Together collective punishment: any user leaving the app destroys all trees in the room • No graceful mid-session exit • Light variable reward through optional 2x coin advertisement watch
Aesthetics	• Achievement-oriented and lightly punitive emotional register • Pride in the cumulative grid, shame in the persistent dead trees • Calm naturalistic visual style; emotional architecture closer to discipline than comfort • Plant Together adds social accountability that often tips into anxiety in user reviews

The following screenshots illustrate specific MDA components in practice.



Alignment with research

Forest performs well on the first target behavior, showing up consistently in small doses, because the grid structure rewards frequency over intensity. It performs less well on the second target behavior, engaging through play rather than discipline, because its emotional engine is closer to fear of loss than to genuine play. The persistence of dead trees as a permanent record of failure is in direct tension with the research finding that successful interventions reward effort rather than punish failure (Wood & R  nger, 2016; Clear, 2018). Forest's most ambitious feature, Plant Together, attempts to deliver the third target behavior, focusing in the presence of others, but the collective-punishment structure of mid-session exit can convert to shared anxiety.

Review notes - Forest

Reviews	Pattern/Takeaway
Tangible for ADHD – 5 stars I am someone who struggles tremendously with studying due to my ADHD. Part of this is because setting restrictions on time and trying to force an intangible structure on myself doesn't work. I can "say" I'll follow a schedule to do my homework, but there's nothing stopping me from straying from that schedule only I have a stake in, so I don't maintain it. This app gives me a time limit that has a tangible consequence for breaking, because the flower or shrub (or TinyTan BTS member) I'm growing will die if I break the rules of the app, and will remain on my forest record forever. I don't want that to happen, so I follow the rules and do what I set out to do originally. However, as is the case for many people who are neurodivergent, setting habits is almost impossible, because one missed step or one missed day ruins the entire process. So opening this app and turning it on to study is a choice you have to actively make every day, and that's difficult. I choose to because I like the act of having a little forest I don't have to maintain in real life, but also because I know I feel worse if I don't study or don't get everything done when I could have, but it took me 2 years to get to this point of knowing the choice to open this app and use it is worth it. It's so hard to do things of my own volition, but this app helps. It's not perfect, but it's better than nothing at all, so I think it's worth the download.	Externalization works for ADHD users, but onboarding is brutal. This user explicitly names what the research literature predicts: intangible self-imposed structure fails for ADHD; tangible external consequence works. Aligns directly with Alabdulkareem & Jamjoom (2020) and Eagle et al. (2024). However, the user reports it took two years to commit.
Forest is my new favorite app - 5 Stars I'll be honest: I'm a student, and I spend WAY TOO MUCH time on my phone. It is a major distraction and I feel myself getting sucked in but was having trouble ever convincing myself to just put it down and get stuff done. I never buy apps (I only go for the free versions of everything) – I literally just paid actual money for my first app ever earlier this year, after owning a smart phone for the past 6 years. This app is well worth the \$2. It helps motivate me to stay off my phone when I'm practicing(music student) or trying to get work done. My boyfriend also has the app and we've made rooms to help us both focus simultaneously a few times but I'm hoping to get more friends to buy it so I can do this more. It is the perfect combination of motivating and making you feel disappointed in yourself if you slip up. Seriously, it's so satisfying to watch your forest grow and it's very easy to use. You can also create new "tags" for why the trees were planted, which I love (I made one specific for	The grid display and the \$3.99 model are doing real work. "Satisfying to watch your forest grow" is exactly the persistent-grid dynamic identified in the MDA analysis. Notably, this user paid for an app for the first time ever, validating the one-time-purchase loyalty pattern. Critical signal on co-presence: they want to use Plant Together with friends but can't, because friends won't buy the app. This is the structural friction the MDA analysis identified: paywalled co-presence collapses the social mechanic for most users. The user explicitly wants more body doubling but is blocked by pricing.

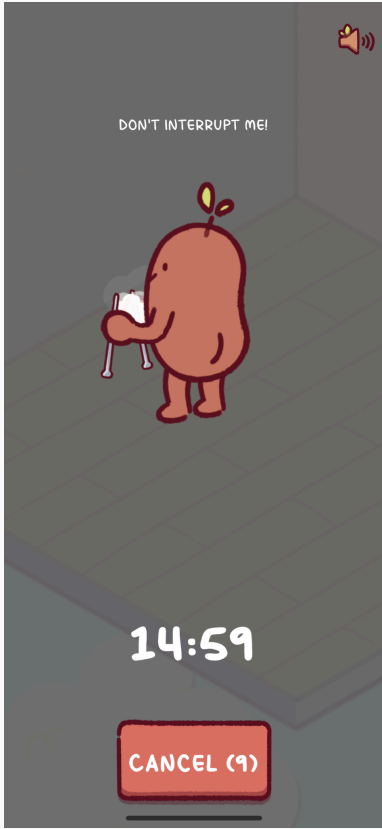
Reviews	Pattern/Takeaway
practicing which is also a good way of keeping track of how much practice I do). I had tried setting time limits for screen time/social media through iPhone settings but I've already started ignoring that...but Forest is so much more convincing and I just can't let my sweet little tries die lol. Overall I love love this app and wish I'd heard of it sooner! It's a relief to have something really hold me accountable for my screen time!	
1 Star If I paid for the app years ago I don't know why suddenly several of the original features are behind a paywall, why I'm constantly being enticed to click on ads for "extra points" and why on earth there is a pause button. Why is every app in such a hurry to brush off their original customer base? After this month I won't be using this app again I can tell you that much	Trust erosion through aesthetic and dynamic shifts. The user identifies three specific changes that broke their relationship with the app: features moving behind paywall, aggressive ad nudges, and the addition of a pause button. The pause-button complaint is significant: it confirms the pattern noted in the broader review literature that Forest's user base wants less flexibility, not more. Adding an escape hatch undermines the core mechanic that made the app work. Aesthetic register shifted from disciplined to compromised.
1 Star Most of the app I paid for is now behind a paywall for a SUBSCRIPTION. Screens are unutterably busy, and basically unusable. You'll spend more time trying to figure out how to use this app than you will ever save by using it. Not to mention the money gouge.	Same monetization complaint, plus UX degradation. Reinforces the previous review's signal.

2. Focus Friend

Released in July 2025 by Hank Green and Honey B Games, Focus Friend reached the top position on the United States App Store within weeks of launch and was named Google Play's App of the Year for 2025. Its critical reception has been driven primarily by its perceived suitability for users with ADHD, a positioning the marketing actively foregrounds.

Focus Friend MDA Breakdown	
Mechanics	- Drag-dial timer (1 minute to 2+ hours) - Bean character animated knitting during the session - Sock currency yielded per completed session - Scarf currency available through Pro subscription - Decoration shop with deterministic furniture purchases - Bean skin variants (Coffee, Edamame, Pinto, Kitty, Hank, John) as flat in-app purchases - No advertisements, no required account, no data collection
Dynamics	- Room-decoration loop drives long-term engagement - Multiple rooms unlock as decoration accumulates (Living Room, Garden added post-launch) - Transient failure mode: bean drops stitches and looks sad, but no persistent record - Pomodoro break timers reinforce the work-rest rhythm with break-as-decoration-time framing - Endgame depth limited: many users report completed decoration within roughly two weeks - No social or co-presence dynamics of any kind
Aesthetics	- Gentle, possessive, parasocial emotional register - Inverted accountability: the user is keeping a small companion happy, not avoiding punishment - ADHD-friendly tone: no shaming, no fear of loss, no public failure indicators - Cozy aesthetic consistent with broader cozy-gaming category

The screenshots below demonstrate Focus Friend's distinctive MDA pattern, particularly the gentle failure mode and the room-decoration progression.

		
MECHANIC Bean animation during focus session. Single visible mechanic: the bean works while the user works. iOS Live Activity extends this presence to the lock screen.	DYNAMIC The transient failure mode: bean drops stitches and looks sad, but no record persists. Next session, Bean is happy again. Direct contrast with Forest's permanent dead trees.	AESTHETIC Room as visible reward and progression artifact. Possessive framing (my bean, my room) anchors the cozy and gentle aesthetic register.

Alignment with research

Focus Friend performs strongly on the second target behavior, engaging through play rather than discipline. The transient and forgiving failure mode aligns directly with the habit-formation research, which holds that sustainable behavior change does not punish deviation. It also performs well on the first target behavior, since the room-decoration loop rewards frequent short sessions over occasional long ones. Where Focus Friend underperforms is on the third target behavior, focusing in the presence of others. The app is intentionally solo, with no social or co-presence features of any kind. This is a defensible design choice, and one many users in the review literature actively praise, but it leaves the relatedness need from Ryan and Deci (2000) unaddressed. For users who would benefit from co-presence, Focus Friend offers no path to it.

Review notes - Focus Friend

Reviews	Pattern/Takeaway
5 Star Review As someone with ADHD I have tried a lot, and I mean A LOT, of different focus apps. Focus Friend is my favorite by a mile because it's actually fun and you get immediate results when you focus. It's cute and adorable and I just want to give my bean a good life!! Thank you Hank Green and team for creating this awesome app!! I am so excited for the new updates with more rooms (hopefully???). Thank you thank you thank you!	The cozy aesthetic and possessive companion framing are doing the core work. Immediate reward plus parasocial care is what the MDA analysis predicts will be helpful.
Good not Great but I Like it But I want More: 4 star review The title says most of it. This has been really helpful for getting me to focus, especially because there's a level of guilt interrupting my bean (Philbert) while they're knitting. HOWEVER, there's not currently enough to decorate. And there are some paid options in the store that I really think should just be built into the game. Maybe 1,000 socks gets you a new bean skin or something. I used this app a few times over a handful of days, and now Philbert's room is fully decorated. So what now? just keep collecting all the different colors of things. Again, I get that the point is to help you get off your phone. But if I'm completing the game within a few days, it's not really helping because now what's the point of me helping my bean focus? I do really like the style and concept, but I'm guessing it's still early days because there's not a lot of goals AFTER you've decorated the room. Hopefully down the road there will be expansions - like a full house or something. Or more specific weird and fun decorations. Or if you're taking a break you could do like a mini game or a word teaser or something. Anyway, in summary, I understand the purpose of the app and it is helpful, but the goal of decorating your bean's room goes by way too fast with no real knowledge about what's next to keep you motivated to keep using it. EDIT: excited to hear they'll be adding more stuff as the app progresses!	Endgame depth gap. Room decoration exhausts quickly, and once it does, the only reason to focus disappears. Confirms the dynamic weakness identified in the MDA analysis.
Once you decorate the two rooms there's nothing left to do. I bought the year subscription and fully decorated everything in less than a month	Same content-depth failure, with monetization sting. Annual subscriber exhausts content in under a month.

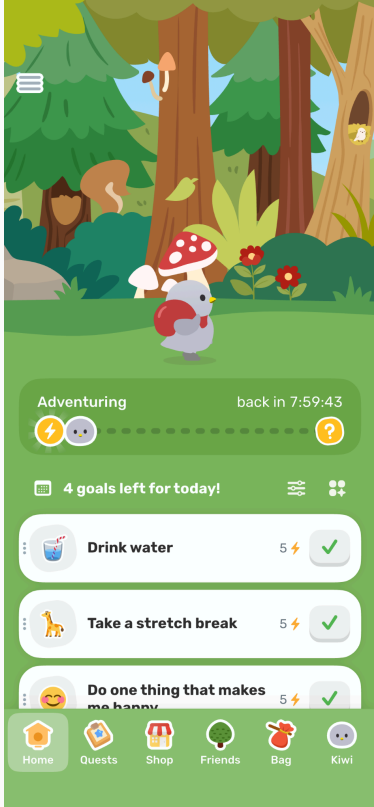
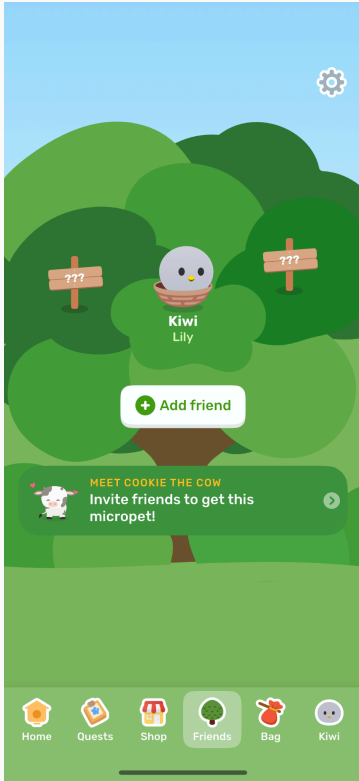
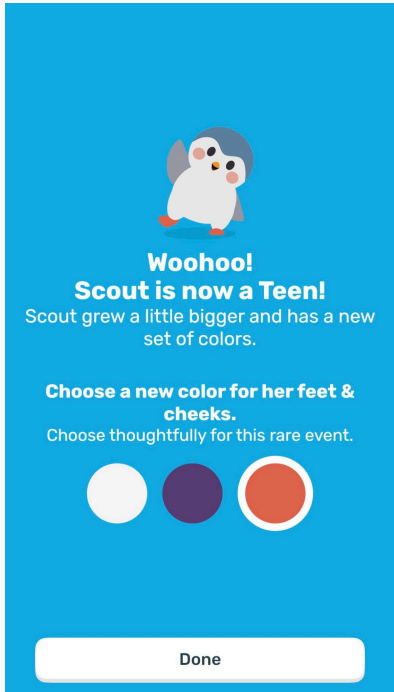
Reviews	Pattern/Takeaway
The app doesn't do anything but start a timer. I can open literally any app and scroll and scroll and scroll. It did take me a minute to realize this, so I was already obsessed with my bean and decorating his room. So my phone is in my hand much more, and my focus has been down dramatically since downloading this. Adorable little bean dude though.	Gentle non-enforcement backfires for low-self-regulation users. The same aesthetic that makes the app appealing makes it ineffective for the ADHD users it markets to.

3. Finch

Released in 2021 by Finch Care, Finch is positioned not as a focus tool but as a self-care application, with focus features included as a secondary offering. It is included in this analysis because its retention mechanics, variable reward structure, and asynchronous social model represent the most sophisticated implementation of the MDA framework currently available in the broader category. It maintains a 4.9 rating across hundreds of thousands of reviews.

Finch: MDA Breakdown	
Mechanics	- Customizable virtual bird (color, name, pronouns, personality trait) - Daily self-care goals (drink water, stretch, reflect on mood) - Energy bar accumulated through completed goals - Rainbow stones currency yielded variably from adventures - Five-character friend code system (no public profiles or feeds) - Pre-written Good Vibes messages (14 free, 4 Plus-only) - Focus timer available in Activities section as secondary feature
Dynamics	- Adventure dynamic: bird leaves birdhouse for ~6 real-time hours after energy bar fills - Variable adventure outcomes (place visited, discoveries made, dialogue) produce variable-ratio reinforcement - Bird visibly evolves across stages (baby, teen, adult) over weeks - Streak tracking with automatic free repairs after consistent use - Seasonal events gated to day three of use as deliberate retention mechanism - Mutual-benefit social dynamic: sending a Good Vibe rewards both sender and receiver - Day-2 morning bird greeting with adventure recap creates the central return-visit hook
Aesthetics	- Inverted self-care emotional register: user receives care from bird, reciprocates by completing goals - Inclusive customization (pronouns, mobility aids, cultural representation) drives loyalty for marginalized users - No failure-shaming language anywhere in the experience - Cozy aesthetic supported by absence of competition, leaderboards, or public profiles - Asynchronous relatedness: connection without scheduling pressure

Finch's screenshots illustrate the variable-reward adventure mechanic, the long-term bird evolution, and the asynchronous Good Vibes social system.

		
DYNAMIC The variable-reward dynamic. Adventure outcomes are randomized and produce variable-ratio reinforcement, which Li et al. (2023) identify as the most engagement-effective gamification pattern.	AESTHETIC Asynchronous social presence. Friends' birds are visible without competition or comparison; the aesthetic is companionship without pressure.	MECHANIC + DYNAMIC Bird's three-stage growth (baby, teen, adult) functions as a long-term progression mechanic that drives multi-week retention, beyond the immediate goal-completion loop.

Alignment with research

Finch performs well on all three target behaviors. It excels at showing up consistently in small doses, with multiple daily check-ins reinforced by widget integration and morning notifications. It excels at engaging through play rather than discipline, with the variable-reward adventure mechanic providing the strongest implementation of intrinsic motivation in the category. Its weakness, relative to the research foundation, is that it does not offer real-time co-presence. The Good Vibes system delivers asynchronous relatedness, which satisfies the need to a degree, but does not produce the live ambient accountability that Eagle et al. (2024) document as most effective for users experiencing task paralysis. For neurodivergent users specifically, Finch offers companionship but not body doubling.

Review notes - Finch

Reviews	PATTERN / TAKEAWAY
5 stars The app is amazing but my biggest gripe is the monthly rewards and micropets. There should be an accept all button. For the ones that have color options just have them at the end and we choose them per item. It's exhausting having to click one by one. This should have been an option a long time ago. The micropets lack whimsy. I usually just get a pompom or a rock like ok? Only monthly micropets are cute 75% of the time and that if you have premium, which I do, but if not you get a plop, droplet, or event worst a blob. 6 thank you for saving my mental health though. I owe you.	Variable rewards work emotionally but the UX friction around claiming them is wearing on power users. Premium subscribers expect higher reward quality.
5 Stars I've been using Finch for nearly two years now and it's been amazing. I struggle a lot with getting tasks done and keeping focused and Finch makes it super easy with the gamification of it all. I've gotten multiple friends into the app as well, which helps even more because you can send each other support with your pets, both adorable and a great reminder to check in. The various exercises, breathing/stretching/etc, are really helpful, and I've found the mental health questionnaires helpful for checking in on myself too. I cannot recommend finch enough it's such a life changer	Multi-year retention with social spread. Confirms the asynchronous social model works: friends-as-support rather than friends-as-competition.
3 Star Honestly all this app did was make me feel bad when I missed a day or a goal on a very long list I had. I love it's purpose and I see how it works for other people, but I felt less like a nurturing bird mom and more like a dog mom whos puppy dies because she forgot to feed it.	The gentle aesthetic can still produce guilt for users who set too many goals at onboarding. The forgiveness mechanics aren't visible enough to overcome the perception of failure.
5 Star This app is the first one I've been even mildly consistent with. I love the customization elements like dressing up your baby and decorating its house. I was able to get some friends in on the app after a coworker recommended it to me. We're all taking care of each other in little ways!	Identity-based customization plus mutual care drives consistency. The "first app I've been consistent with" framing matters: low activation cost is what made the difference.

Master Comparison

The chart below summarizes the three apps across the MDA framework and the three target behaviors identified in the research foundation. This is the central diagnostic of the competitive landscape.

	Forest	Focus Friend	Finch
Mechanics	Timer + coins + tree shop Tags for time accounting Real-tree donation cap (5 max)	Timer + bean + sock currency Decoration shop Premium scarf currency	Goals + energy + stones Bird customization Friend code social system
Dynamics	Trophy-case grid Sunk-cost dead trees Plant Together collective punishment	Room decoration loop Transient gentle failure Limited endgame depth	Variable adventures (6-hr cycle) Bird evolution stages Mutual-benefit Good Vibes
Aesthetics	Achievement and discipline Light shame from dead trees Naturalistic but punitive	Gentle, parasocial, possessive ADHD-friendly tone Cozy register, no shaming	Inverted self-care Inclusive customization Asynchronous companionship
Target Behaviors			
Showing up consistently in small doses	Strong: grid rewards frequency	Strong: decoration loop rewards short sessions	Strongest: multi-touch daily structure
Engaging through play, not discipline	Weak: fear-of-loss engine	Strong: forgiving, gentle	Strongest: variable rewards, no shaming
Focusing in presence of others	Attempted with collective punishment	Absent: solo by design	Partial: asynchronous only

The Competitive Gap

Mapped against the MDA framework and the three target behaviors, the existing landscape leaves a structural gap. Forest delivers attempted co-presence but at the cost of punitive collective dynamics. Focus Friend delivers gentle play but no co-presence at all. Finch delivers the most sophisticated mechanics and dynamics in the category but offers only asynchronous relatedness, not live presence. No existing tool in the focus-and-self-care space simultaneously delivers cozy aesthetic comfort, forgiving dynamics, and real-time co-presence with other users. This is the gap that motivates the design of Catena.

Part Four: Catena (write later)

11. Introduction to Catena What it is, the cat café, the chained Pomodoro structure, the cozy aesthetic.

12. Catena Through the MDA Framework Mirror the structure used for the three competitors. MDA chart, screenshot slots if you have a working build, alignment with research.

13. How Catena Addresses Each Problem Behavior Direct mapping: for each of the three problem behaviors in the research foundation, here is the Catena feature that addresses it.

14. Where Catena Differs from competitors is what Catena borrows from each competitor, what it explicitly rejects, and where it goes beyond all three.

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